

Lekshmi Radhakrishnan

Greater Boston · lekshmi_radhakrishnan@fas.harvard.edu
ORCID: 0009-0000-4714-7868 · lekshmiradhakrishnan.github.io

RESEARCH INTERESTS

My work is about classification accuracy in psychopathology. Culture, for these purposes, is the set of interpretive frames a person inherits — transmitted across generations rather than chosen — and I study how those frames shape the way distress is expressed and recognized, where that produces diagnostic error, and who is left without care as a result. Cultural distance between clinician and patient generates misclassification in both directions: pathologizing what is culturally ordinary, and missing genuine illness expressed in unfamiliar idioms. I treat this as an empirical question about measurement validity rather than a claim about clinical sensitivity, and a central methodological concern is whether measures of distress retain the same meaning across groups that differ in those frames. I approach it across levels, integrating neurobiological, developmental, cultural, and ecological factors, using ambulatory assessment (ecological momentary assessment, heart rate variability), neuroimaging, cross-cultural and computational methods, and health-services research on structural barriers to care. Current projects span anxiety and obsessive-compulsive spectrum conditions in the perinatal period, cultural evolution of belief and moral judgment, and comparative neuroscience of social bonding.

EDUCATION

Harvard University, Extension School — Cambridge, MA **2024 – Present**

Master of Liberal Arts (ALM), Psychology · GPA: 3.9/4.0 · Expected 2027

- **Graduate coursework:** Cognitive Neuroscience (Elizabeth Phelps) · Markers of Psychopathology · Introduction to Medical Neuroscience · Statistics: Methods and Modeling · Dogs: Behavior and Evolution (Erin Hecht) · Proseminar in Graduate Study
- **Statistics sequence:** Introduction to Quantitative Methods · Introduction to Statistical Modeling · Statistics: Methods and Modeling — three courses in applied statistics and modeling
- **Additional coursework:** Psychology of Diversity (Mona Weissmark) · Race in a Polarized America (Jennifer Hochschild) · Deliberative Justice
- **Master's thesis:** Advisor: Richard J. McNally, PhD.
- **Additional graduate coursework (audited):** Primate Social Behavior; The *Pan* Model for Human Evolution — Martin Surbeck, PhD, Department of Human Evolutionary Biology (Fall 2025)

Thomas Edison State University — Trenton, NJ

Bachelor of Arts, Liberal Studies · GPA: 4.0/4.0

- **Capstone:** *Unraveling Gender Disparity: Analyzing the Absence of a Woman President in America* · Advisor: Catherine Peck, PhD. A study of the cultural, structural, and knowledge barriers to women's political leadership in the United States, drawing on ambivalent sexism, system justification theory, and social role theory.

Wichita State University — Wichita, KS

Post-baccalaureate coursework in psychology

University of Kerala — Kerala, India

Bachelor of Arts, Psychology

- Coursework included developmental, abnormal, and industrial psychology.

HONORS & ACADEMIC DISTINCTIONS

- **Psi Chi**, International Honor Society in Psychology — elected member, Wichita State University chapter
- **Dean's Honor Roll** — Wichita State University
- **President's List** — Thomas Edison State University

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

Conrad, R. C., Koire, A., **Radhakrishnan, L.**, Charroux, A., Klingler, S., Benson, N. M., & Boyd, J. W. (2025). Impact of state medical licensure exemptions and telehealth registries on college students' access to psychiatric care. *Psychiatric Services*, 76(6), 602–605. <https://doi.org/10.1176/appi.ps.20240225>

Media Coverage

Many psychiatrists unaware of state license exemptions. Psychiatric News (March 2025). Coverage of Conrad et al. (2025). <https://doi.org/10.1176/appi.pn.2025.03.3.42>

Manuscripts Under Review

Hecht, E. E., Rogers Flattery, C., Abdulla, M., Michlich, J., **Radhakrishnan, L.**, Dooyema, J., Chavez Flores, A., Swardstrom, R., Rogers, F., Helen, J., Althammer, F., Kukekova, A. V., & Sherwood, C. C. (2026). Hypothalamic oxytocin and vasopressin cell populations do not differ across selectively-bred silver fox lineages but covary with brain-wide structural organization. *Journal of Comparative Neurology* (minor revision submitted September 2026).

Manuscripts in Preparation

Systematic review of the co-occurrence between obsessive beliefs and specific OCD symptom dimensions. *Manuscript in preparation.*

INVITED PRESENTATIONS & POLICY BRIEFINGS

Radhakrishnan, L. & Conrad, R. C. (2023). *Interstate licensure barriers to college students' access to psychiatric care.* Series of invited briefings on study findings, co-presented with R. C. Conrad at each, to state medical board leadership, health policy organizations, and academic and legal experts — including the Massachusetts Board of Registration in Medicine, the Commonwealth Fund, the ERISA Industry Committee, Connect With Care, and faculty at Harvard Medical School, Harvard Law School, and Northeastern University School of Law.

Radhakrishnan, L. (2024, April 21). *Unraveling gender disparity: Analyzing the absence of a woman president in America.* Capstone oral presentation, Liberal Arts Capstone (LIB 4950), Thomas Edison State University.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant — Department of Psychology, Harvard University **Sept. 2026 – Present**
Principal Investigator: Joshua Conrad Jackson, PhD · Cultural Dynamics Lab

- Contribute to research on cultural evolution and the psychology of belief, moral judgment, and emotion across societies.

Graduate Researcher and Thesis Student — Department of Psychology, Harvard University **2026 – Present**
Thesis Advisor and Principal Investigator: Richard J. McNally, PhD

- Investigate perinatal trauma risk using heart rate variability (HRV) and ecological momentary assessment (EMA) to capture symptom dynamics in real-world settings.
- Contribute to a new study of perinatal obsessive-compulsive disorder.
- Conduct systematic data extraction and screening for a review of the co-occurrence between obsessive beliefs and specific OCD symptom dimensions.
- Prepare IRB protocols and informed consent documentation; conduct literature reviews and design psychoeducational resource materials for study participants.

Research Affiliate — Surbeck Lab (Pan Lab), Human Evolutionary Biology, Harvard University **2025 – Present**
Principal Investigator: Martin Surbeck, PhD

- Cleaned and organised existing GPS ranging data from bonobo field research to prepare it for spatial analysis.
- Contribute to project discussion and study design in weekly Pan Lab meetings and the Pan Seminar series on bonobo and chimpanzee social behavior, cognition, and cultural evolution.
- Received direct guidance from Dr. Surbeck on the bonobo female-coalition and leadership literature underpinning the independent intervention study below.

Independent Research Proposal — Harvard University **2025 – Present**
Does Evidence About a Closely Related Species Change What People Take to Be Biologically Fixed?

- Designed an original study testing whether brief exposure to documentary material on bonobo social organisation, including female coalitions and leadership, produces measurable shifts in beliefs about sex differences, assessed by Implicit Association Test and open-ended reflection; the underlying question concerns belief revision in response to biological evidence.
- Authored a comprehensive literature review situating the intervention across primatology, implicit social cognition, and the counterstereotypical role-model literature; specified the pilot protocol, control condition, and analysis plan independently.
- Originated in the graduate proseminar (SSCI S-100A, Summer 2025) and carried beyond the coursework, including consultation with faculty in primatology, evolutionary neuroscience, and affective neuroscience on design, literature, and feasibility.

Research Assistant — Department of Human Evolutionary Biology, Harvard University 2024 – 2026

Principal Investigator: Erin E. Hecht, PhD · Evolutionary Neuroscience Lab & Canine Brains Project

- Acquired human and canine MRI data (MRI safety certified, Yellow Badge), including pediatric neuroimaging and mock-scanner desensitization training in collaboration with the Gaab Lab (CALC study).
- Collected and processed behavioral and neuroimaging data from pediatric participants (ages 7–12) examining the human–canine bond and cross-species developmental markers.
- Performed stereological quantification of oxytocin- and vasopressin-producing neurons in the supraoptic and paraventricular hypothalamic nuclei of tame, aggressive, and unselected silver fox lineages (Russian farm-fox experiment; n = 18), using immunohistochemistry and unbiased sampling methods.
- Took over the cell-counting project, which had already changed hands more than once, when the graduate student then running it left the lab; coordinated the remaining counters and brought the dataset to a publishable endpoint (manuscript under review; fifth of thirteen authors).
- Performed histological processing and sectioning of brain tissue to investigate neural substrates of behavior and cognition across species.
- Administered canine behavior testing protocols and coded behavioral video data for cross-species cognition and social-bonding studies.
- Led participant recruitment and family communication, coordinating longitudinal study schedules and ensuring protocol adherence and data integrity.

Laboratory Assistant — ASPR Paleo Lab, Peabody Museum, Harvard University 2026 – Present

- Conduct osteological research including specimen handling, curation, and systematic data logging; manage ethical repatriation logistics in compliance with NAGPRA and institutional standards.

Research Assistant — Center for Bioethics, Harvard Medical School 2023 – 2024

Principal Investigator: Rachel C. Conrad, MD

- Co-authored a peer-reviewed study in Psychiatric Services (third author) quantifying how state licensure exemptions and telehealth registries shape college students' access to psychiatric care.
- Designed and executed a multi-state "secret shopper" study assessing real-world availability of cross-state telepsychiatry for students.
- Translated findings into policy recommendations and presented to 15+ state and federal stakeholders, including medical board presidents, legislators, and legal experts.

Research Assistant — Science of Diversity Lab, Harvard University 2022 – 2023

Principal Investigator: Mona Weissmark, PhD

- Supported editorial preparation of *Seeing the Other Side: Shifting Perceptions*, a scholarly treatment of intergroup perspective-taking, transgenerational trauma, and the psychology of cultural and racial difference, ensuring manuscript clarity, stylistic consistency, and adherence to publishing guidelines.
- Conducted fact-checking and reference verification across the manuscript to ensure empirical accuracy.

CLINICAL & APPLIED MENTAL HEALTH EXPERIENCE

Team Leader — Psychiatric Assisted Living Facility 2 years

Mental Health Association of South Central Kansas — Wichita, KS

- Managed a residential psychiatric facility serving 30+ adults with chronic psychiatric conditions, predominantly psychotic-spectrum disorders including paranoid schizophrenia, supporting their transition to community living and daily functioning.
- Designed and implemented individualized care plans and activity modifications to improve quality of life and therapeutic outcomes.
- Delivered direct psychological support and crisis intervention, promoting stability and long-term recovery.
- Built daily living skills and reinforced self-efficacy, supporting residents toward greater independence and productive community roles.
- Maintained comprehensive clinical documentation, including patient records, treatment plans, progress notes, and service reports.
- Trained and supervised staff on regulatory compliance and adherence to state mental health standards and procedures.
- Conducted functional assessments and formal intake and treatment-plan reviews, and authored detailed daily progress documentation for each resident.
- Supported a substantial immigrant and non-English-speaking resident population, adapting care planning and daily communication across language and cultural difference.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant — HEB 50: Human Metabolism **Fall 2026**
Department of Human Evolutionary Biology, Harvard University · Head Instructor: Andrew Yegian, PhD
• Lead weekly discussion and laboratory sections for an oversubscribed undergraduate course.

Teaching Assistant — HEB 140: Evolution of Friendship **2025 – 2026**
Department of Human Evolutionary Biology, Harvard University · Head Instructor: Jennifer Devereaux, PhD
• Delivered lectures and led weekly discussion sections for undergraduate and graduate students on the evolutionary, psychological, cultural, and social dimensions of social bonding.
• Graded research papers and empirical critiques, providing individualized analytic feedback and academic support.
• Collaborated with the head instructor to refine course structure and assignment rubrics.

RESEARCH SKILLS & METHODS

Neuroimaging: MRI data acquisition (MRI safety certified, Yellow Badge); pediatric neuroimaging protocols; mock-scanner desensitization training; structural MRI data organization and quality control.

Laboratory: Immunohistochemistry and stereological quantification of neuropeptide-producing cell populations, histological processing and sectioning of brain tissue, specimen curation and osteological analysis.

Assessment & Measurement: Ecological momentary assessment (EMA), heart rate variability (HRV) collection and processing, behavioral and cognitive testing batteries, psychometric assessment, structured systematic review and data extraction.

Statistical & Computational: R, Python, C++, Java.

Regulatory & Research Administration: IRB and IACUC protocol preparation and amendment, informed consent procedures, human subjects regulatory compliance, participant recruitment and retention, longitudinal study coordination, family scheduling and communication.

Tools: REDCap, Qualtrics, Git, Zotero, Paperpile, Microsoft Office, Google Workspace.

Communication & Interviewing: Professional broadcast and live presenting experience (television, public events); structured interviewing of public figures; production and presentation of video material for general audiences — directly applicable to media-based intervention design and to qualitative interviewing.

Cross-Cultural Research: Cross-cultural survey design and administration, culturally adapted participant recruitment and retention, community-engaged research with Indigenous and diaspora populations, qualitative interviewing across languages.

Languages: English, Malayalam, Tamil, Hindi (fluent) — enabling participant recruitment, interviewing, and data collection in South Asian and diaspora communities without an interpreter.

CERTIFICATIONS & TRAINING

- MRI Safety Certification (Yellow Badge) — Harvard University Center for Brain Science
- Certified Youth & Adult Mental Health First Aider — National Council for Mental Wellbeing
- Certificate in Social Justice — Harvard Extension School
- Certificate in Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) Interventions — Stellenbosch University
- CITI Program — Researchers, Basic Course (Stage 1), Harvard University; initially completed 2024, renewed January 2026 (current through January 2027)

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

- **Association for Behavioral and Cognitive Therapies (ABCT)** — Student Member, 2026 – Present
- **ABCT Special Interest Groups:** Asian American Issues in Behavior Therapy and Research · Psychosis and Schizophrenia Spectrum (PASS) · Clinical Research Methods and Statistics · Dissemination and Implementation Science

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE & LEADERSHIP

Treasurer — Psi Chi, International Honor Society in Psychology, Wichita State University chapter

Board Member — New Guinea Singing Dog Conservation Society **2026 – Present**

Executive Committee Member — Committee on the Concerns of Women at Harvard (CCW) **2025 – Present**

Executive Member — Healthy Youth Initiative Coalition, Mercer Island, WA **2021 – 2024**

- Served on an interdisciplinary coalition of school administrators, mental health professionals, educators, and public safety officials advancing youth mental health, school safety, and equitable education access.

Vice President of Advocacy & Communications — PTA Council, Mercer Island, WA 2020 – 2022

- Advocated for district- and state-level mental health legislation and resource equity as Legislation Chair, coordinating implementation of national advocacy programs.
- Co-founded and led the Action Committee for Environmental Sustainability (ACES), building community partnerships and district-wide sustainability initiatives.

CROSS-CULTURAL & COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

- **Volunteer Coordinator** — Attappady Hill Area Development Society, Kerala, India. Partnered with Indigenous Adivasi communities on capacity-building and sustainable land management, coordinating local volunteers and securing funding for community-led income-generating initiatives.
- **Board of Directors, Treasurer & Event Coordinator** — Child Rights and You (CRY), Houston, TX. Led awareness campaigns on children's welfare and educational access across both Indian-American and broader U.S. audiences; oversaw financial reporting and strategic performance tracking.
- **Co-Founder** — South Asian Parent Affinity Group, Mercer Island, WA. Built a cultural affinity space to increase visibility and belonging for South Asian families, and convened listening sessions with district leadership on culturally responsive school practice.
- **Volunteer Educator** — Seaside Elementary School, Torrance, CA. Provided K–5 literacy, mathematics, and science instruction at an under-resourced public school; adapted instruction for diverse learning needs and fostered family engagement.
- **Volunteer** — The Friday Café at First Church, Cambridge, MA (2025 – Present), community support for neighbors experiencing homelessness; **Member**, Citizens' Climate Lobby (2023 – Present).